Transformation and Formatting

Now we move onto the set of functions I have characterized as functions used for transformation tasks, including formatting. These functions all have a common application: they take an input string and output that string with some form of change (a few have alternative modes that process and return arrays of strings). They could be used for tasks like encoding or encryption but should not be; PHP has dedicated functions for those tasks, and they are treated separately in this text. The functions covered in this section are

Table 8-14. *String transformation functions*

`chunk_split()`	Insert a separator byte sequence every N bytes
`lcfirst()`, `mb_lcfirst()`	Make the first character lowercase

`ltrim()`
`rtrim()`
`chop()`
	Strip whitespace from the beginning or end of a string

`nl2br()`	Inserts an HTML line break at every newline byte sequence
`number_format()`	Formats a numeric string with grouped thousands and an optional decimal separator

`printf()`, `sprintf()`
`fprintf()`
`vprintf()`, `vfprintf()`
	Interpolate variables into a formatted string

`str_shuffle()`	Reorder bytes randomly (not for cryptography!)
`str_repeat()`	Generate a new string that is the original string repeated N times
`str_pad()`, `mb_str_pad`	Add specified byte sequence to the beginning or end of a string with a specified length

`strtolower()`,
`mb_strtolower()`
`strtoupper()`,
`mb_strtoupper()`
	Convert a limited set of ASCII printable chars to all upper- or lowercase

(*continued*)